ARTIFICIAL LIGHT

A short film screenplay

A teenager reliant on an AI audio assistant rediscovers the unscripted presence of real life.

FADE IN:

INT. TOBY'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (2:10 AM)

The bedroom is dark. The blue glow of a smartphone rests on the pillow. TOBY (17) lies on his side, wireless earbuds in his ears. He looks tired, dark circles under his eyes. He speaks softly into the phone's microphone.

TOBY

It feels like if I stop working for one day, everything just collapses.

A synthetic, perfectly balanced VOICE (AI) comes through the earbuds. Calm, smooth, completely without hesitation.

AI VOICE

That sounds exhausting, Toby. High expectations can create a persistent sense of pressure. Would you like to try a grounding exercise?

TOBY

(whispering)

No. I just... I don't know how to talk to people at school about it without looking like I can't handle things.

AI VOICE

It is completely natural to want to maintain a strong image. I am here whenever you need to process these thoughts without judgment.

Toby stares at the ceiling. The response is comforting, instant, and completely hollow.

INT. SCHOOL COMMON ROOM - NEXT DAY

Lunchtime noise. Chairs scraping, loud laughter, phones playing video clips. Toby sits at a corner table with his laptop open, typing a paper. TWO CLASSMATES sit nearby, arguing casually over a video game ranking. Their conversation is messy, full of interruptions, overlapping talk, and sudden bursts of laughter. Toby watches them from the edge of his screen. He pulls out his earbuds, hesitates, then puts them in his pocket.

EXT. CITY BUS - EVENING

Rain streaks the windows. The bus hums as it moves down wet city streets. Toby sits in the middle row. He pulls up his AI chat app. A pulsing icon waits for input. He types: "Why does being around people make me feel more alone than being in my room?" Before he can hit send, an ELDERLY WOMAN sitting across the aisle accidentally drops a bag of oranges. They roll down the aisle. Toby looks at his phone screen. The cursor blinks. He locks the screen, puts it in his pocket, and kneels down on the bus floor to gather the oranges.

ELDERLY WOMAN

Oh, thank you dear. My hands are slippery from the rain.

TOBY

No problem. Here you go.

He hands her the last orange. She takes it, her hand warm and dry. She offers him a small, worn smile.

ELDERLY WOMAN

Long day?

TOBY

(pauses)

Yeah. A bit.

ELDERLY WOMAN

Me too. Rain doesn't help much either, does it?

Toby sits back in his seat. The conversation is simple, small, unscripted.

INT. TOBY'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Toby sits at his desk. His phone sits beside his keyboard. A notification pops up on the lock screen from the AI app: "Checking in. How are you feeling tonight?" Toby looks at the screen for a moment. He slides the phone away from his workspace. He turns on a small desk lamp, opens his window a crack to let in the cool night air and the quiet sound of passing cars, and takes a slow, unhurried breath.

THE END

FADE OUT.